organisation.[5] They may have been genuinely apprehensive of being isolated in a largely Europeanised and integrated world if they reverted to their precolonial political institutions. In today's telecom parlance, this can be compared with the situation of a mobile network operator, who, in the interest of interoperability, must comply with the technological standards laid down by the European Telecommunications Standards Institute (ETSI), failing which, the former's mobile phone users cannot interact with the users of other telecom operators that comply with the ETSI standards. Crudely speaking, similar considerations would have weighed on most colonised societies upon achieving political independence since the world's economy revolved around the West.

Therefore, given the omnipresence of European politico-economic and cultural coloniality, perhaps the only viable option available to the newly decolonised societies was to embrace the political structures, institutions and lexicon left behind by the coloniser to avoid the prospect of disintegration, annexation, anarchy and global isolation. However, broadly speaking, decolonised societies fell into two categories. In the first category, those societies that had a strong sense of indigenous consciousness, or whatever remained of it after centuries of colonialism, sought to compensate for continuing with European political legacy by infusing the edifice with ideas drawn from their cultures or by customising European definitions to suit their cultural palate. In the second category, those societies that were helmed by colonialised native elites became crucibles for a constant struggle between such elites and the native masses that had been relegated to the status of 'subalterns', and pushed to the margins of the process of nation-building. In this category of societies, on the one hand, the colonialised Europeanised native elites had stepped into the shoes of the coloniser to recast the native masses and the society in the European mould; on the other hand, the native masses were torn between the aspiration projected by the rulers to 'catch up' with the West and the opportunity history had finally presented them with to reclaim their roots, consciousness and identity. It was in the latter category of societies that coloniality manifested itself in all its glory, especially in the spheres of political thought, environment, language, religion, law, gender, economics, production of knowledge, education and even popular culture.[6]

To add to the woes of decolonised societies, while the era of colonialism was over, its place was occupied by an even more worthy successor—